You got an email from PoL Microscopy Data Management. What does it mean?

A short guide for users of the PoL Microscopy instruments and processing computers. It explains the emails, data structure rules, and common issues.

In short Which email did I get? Where my data must be Reading the email Troubleshooting Questions

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In short

1. Storage on the microscope and processing computers is **temporary**. Data is deleted automatically after a set time.
2. You are warned by email **before** anything is deleted. Email tells you the **exact deletion date**.
3. Copy everything you want to keep to **your own storage** (group share, project storage, ...) before the deletion date.
4. Keep your data in the right place: **your email-named folder** (and, on processing computers, inside a **PROJECT** folder).
5. Deleted data **cannot be restored**.

Which email did I get?

Every email starts with `PoL Data Storage - <system name>:`, so you always know which acquisition or processing computer it is about. Find your email by its subject:

```
… N file(s) (… GB) due for deletion on 18 Nov 2026
… N PROJECT folder(s) (… GB) due for deletion on 18 Nov 2026
```

A **warning**. The listed data will be deleted on that date. You get reminders as the date comes closer (e.g. 2 weeks, 1 week, 3 days and 1 day before). If the computer is switched off for a long time, some reminders are skipped, and the data can be deleted without a further reminder when it is back on. **Don’t wait for the last reminder.**

→ Copy the data you want to keep to your own storage before the date. Data you don’t need: nothing to do.

`… N file(s) have exceeded the …-day retention period`
`… N PROJECT folder(s) have reached the end of their retention period`

A **final notice**: this data is already past its time and will be deleted on the next run, usually the next day.

`… Done – N file(s) deleted`
`… N PROJECT folder(s) deleted (… GB)`

The data has been **deleted**. The attached list shows exactly which files.

`… File issue(s) in your PROJECTS folder`

Some of your files are **not in the right place** (processing computers): they are not inside a `PROJECT` folder. See Where my data must be.

→ Move these files into a PROJECT folder (e.g. `PROJECT1`), or copy them to your own storage and remove them.

`[Data Storage TEST - …] …`

Any subject starting with `[Data Storage TEST` is a **test** by the facility. It checks that emails reach you. Nothing was deleted.

→ Nothing to do.

One email can contain several of these at once, e.g. “1 PROJECT folder deleted” plus a warning for another folder plus file issues.

Where my data must be

On every computer there is a folder called `PROJECTS`. Inside it, **your** folder is named exactly like your email address. That name is how the system knows whom to email.

On a microscope (acquisition) computer

Everything goes into your email-named folder. Inside it, you can organise your data however you like. Each file is deleted after the set time (e.g. 42 days after it was last changed).

✔ Right

```
D:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── 2026-10-20_zebrafish\
    │   └── Position1\T0001.czi
    └── 2026-11-02_test\…
```

✘ Wrong

```
D:\
├── Anna\…                ← not in PROJECTS
└── PROJECTS\
    ├── anna.muster\…     ← no email address
    └── anna.muster@tu-dresden\…
                          ← ".de" missing
```

On a processing computer

Inside your email-named folder, every project gets its own `PROJECT` folder: `PROJECT0`, `PROJECT1`, `PROJECT2`, … A PROJECT folder is kept as a whole for a set time (e.g. at least 90 days after it was created, and 42 days after the last change inside it), then the whole folder is deleted.

✔ Right

```
P:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── PROJECT1\
    │   ├── raw\…
    │   └── analysis\…
    └── PROJECT2\…
```

✘ Wrong — reported as "file issue"

```
P:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── results.xlsx      ← loose file
    ├── fiji-windows-x64.exe
    ├── my_analysis\…     ← not a PROJECT
    └── PROJECT_1\…       ← underscore
```

Which PROJECT folder names work?

FOLDER NAME	COUNTS AS PROJECT FOLDER?
`PROJECT1`, `PROJECT0`, `PROJECT12`	✔ Yes
`project1`, `Project2`	✔ Yes (capitalisation doesn't matter)
`PROJECT_1`, `PROJECT 1`, `PROJECT-1`	✘ No — no space, dash or underscore
`PROJECT1_old`, `PROJECT1 (copy)`	✘ No — nothing after the number
`PROJECT`, `Projects`, `MyProject1`	✘ No — "PROJECT" followed directly by a number

Why does it matter? Files outside a PROJECT folder are not looked after: you get a "file issue" reminder instead of a proper deletion schedule, and such data is **not safe** on the computer and could be deleted in the near future.

Typo in your folder name = no emails. If your folder isn't named exactly like your email address, the system can't warn you, but your data is still cleaned up. Please carefully check the spelling, including the domain (e.g. `@tu-dresden.de`, `@mpi-cbg.de`).

Reading the email

A typical warning looks like this (numbers explained below):

Subject: PoL Data Storage - LSM980: 2 PROJECT folder(s) (85.2 GB) due for deletion on 6 Nov 2026
Attachment: 📎 PoL_Data_Storage_LSM980_full_list_2026-11-03.html 6

Dear LSM980 user,

2 PROJECT folders (85.2 GB) will be deleted soon, starting 6 Nov 2026. Please move any data you want to keep.

Some of your files are not located in the correct PROJECT folder. Please move their contents into a PROJECT folder, as data kept outside a PROJECT folder is not safe and could be deleted. 1

File issue(s)
The following item(s) … are located outside of a PROJECT folder:

```
results.xlsx (file, 24.1 KB)
my_analysis (folder, 3.2 GB)
```

… and 3 more item(s) — all are listed in the attached file

A PROJECT folder is currently kept for at least 90 days after it was created.

Your PROJECT folders

Not scheduled for deletion | upcoming (≤ 21 days) | due (< 1 week) 2

	FOLDER / BIGGEST FILES	AGE	LAST CHANGE	SIZE	DELETION
	**P:\PROJECTS\anna.muster@tu-dresden.de**		212 file(s)	160.4 GB	85.2 GB due or upcoming
	**PROJECT2** 3	13 weeks (92 days)	12 Sep 2026	48.0 GB	6 Nov 2026 (in 3 days) 4 **Due**
	raw/stack_0012.czi 5			4.1 GB	
	… and 41 more file(s) in this folder (39.2 GB)				
	**PROJECT3**	12 weeks (84 days)	20 Sep 2026	37.2 GB	17 Nov 2026 (in 14 days) **Upcoming**
	**PROJECT4**	3 weeks (21 days)	1 Nov 2026	72.0 GB	1 Feb 2027 (in 90 days) **Not scheduled for deletion**

1. **File issues** (processing computers): files that are not in a PROJECT folder. At most 5 are shown; the attachment lists all of them.
2. **Colours:** green = not scheduled for deletion yet · orange = upcoming (the warning period has started) · red = due, deleted in less than a week.
3. **One row per folder** — on processing computers per PROJECT folder, on microscope computers per folder in your email folder, most urgent first.
4. **Deletion date** with a countdown. If a folder's files have different dates, you see a range, e.g. "4–6 Nov 2026 (in 1–3 days)".
5. **The biggest files** of that folder (up to 5), so you see where most of the space is.
6. **The attachment** lists **every** file with its deletion date (and, after a deletion, the files that were deleted). It opens in any web browser. Long names are shortened in the email, but complete in the attachment.

The colours

Not scheduled for deletion
Nothing to do yet.

Upcoming
The warning period has started. Plan to copy what you need.

Due (< 1 week)
Deleted within a week. Copy now.

How the dates are calculated

- **Microscope computers:** each file is deleted a set number of days after it was **last changed** (its "modified" date). Opening or viewing a file does not change that date.
- **Processing computers:** a PROJECT folder is kept at least a set time after it was **created**, and also a set time after the **last change** to anything inside it — whichever is later. Working in a project keeps it alive.
- The exact periods can differ between computers. **The date in your email is always the real one.**
- Normally, nothing is deleted sooner than 2 weeks after your first warning about it.

Troubleshooting

“I moved my data to another folder on the same computer but it was still deleted.”

Moving data around *on the computer* doesn’t keep it. Copy it to **your own storage** (group share, project storage, external drive) before the deletion date.

“My folder name was slightly different, so I never got an email.”

The folder must be named exactly like your email address, e.g. `anna.muster@tu-dresden.de`. A typo, a missing “.de” or just your name means the system can’t reach you.

“I put my files directly in my email folder on the processing computer.”

On processing computers, data belongs in a PROJECT folder (`PROJECT1`, `PROJECT2`, …). Loose files and other folders are reported as “file issues” and are not looked after.

“I named my folder PROJECT_1 / Project 1 / PROJECT1_final.”

Only “PROJECT” followed directly by a number counts (capitalisation doesn’t matter). See the table above.

“I copied old data onto the computer and it got a warning right away.”

A copy often keeps the original “modified” date of the files, so old data counts as old even if you copied it today. You will normally still get about 2 weeks’ notice before such data is deleted.

Questions

Can deleted data be restored?

No. Once the deletion email has arrived, the data is gone from that computer.

Why do I get several emails about the same data?

You get reminders as the deletion date comes closer (for example 2 weeks, 1 week, 3 days and 1 day before). Each reminder is sent only once. If the computer was switched off for a long time, you may get fewer reminders: the deletion date from the first warning still applies.

How do I open the attachment?

It is a small web page (`.html`). Open it with any browser, double-click it, or save it and open it. It lists every file with its size and deletion date.

Some small files aren't listed — why?

Very small files (e.g. system files like `.DS_Store` or `Thumbs.db`) are left out of the emails to keep them readable. They follow the same schedule.

I need more time for my data.

Contact us before the deletion date and we'll find a solution.

Questions or problems? Write to pol_microscopy@tu-dresden.de.
